had crossed the lines and surrendered himself to Mohan Lal, whom he knew from the munshi's days as an 'intelligencer' in Kandahar working for Wade in the mid-1830s. Debriefing him in his tent, Mohan Lal discovered that according to the Prince the fortress had one major weak point. Most of the fortress gates had been bricked up as the British approached, but the Kabul Gate had been left open so as to allow continued communication with Dost Mohammad. When Burnes passed the information to Keane, the Commander-in-Chief decided he had no option but to attack that very night and hope that surprise would make up for the lack of intelligence and planning.

A plan was quickly put together. An artillery barrage and a diversionary attack to the south would provide cover for a party of engineers to creep up and lay the charges to blow the Kabul Gate. This would be followed by a mass assault with fixed bayonets. 'Such an operation was full of risk,' wrote Henry Durand, who volunteered to lead the explosives party. 'Even success could only be anticipated at the cost of a heavy loss of men.' When Durand raised these risks with Keane, the Commander-in-Chief replied that there was simply no alternative, as there was only two or three days of food left in the commissariat.[88]

The rest of the day was spent in reconnaissance as Keane and the engineers rode around the outer walls of the fort, using the shelter of the belt of walled gardens of apricots and walnuts at its foot to avoid the bullets of the jezail-snipers on the battlements. Just before midnight, orders were sent out that the troops should assemble at 4 a.m., and should remove the white covers of their caps so as to be less visible from the ramparts. At 2 a.m. Shuja was taken to the hill immediately above the Kabul Gate by Macnaghten. According to his biographer, Mohammad Husain Herati, 'William Macnaghten was honoured to enter the royal presence and to invite His Majesty to proceed to the hill of the shrine of the wise Sufi saint Bahlul, from where he would be able to observe the storming of Ghazni fort. As soon as His Majesty had taken up his position, the blazing fire of cannons started.'[89] In his exposed position Shuja came under heavy fire from the ramparts, but remained there with icy courage, impressing his British minders who had been told misleading stories about his previous premature exits from the field of battle.

Sita Ram was part of the diversionary force. 'Orders were given to keep up a hot fire to deceive and distract the attention of the ghazis,' he wrote.